EXP - 11

Deploying a Zoho Creator Application from Development to Production

Aim

To understand and carry out the deployment of a Zoho Creator application from the development environment to the production environment.

Introduction

Building an application is only half the job; releasing it safely to real users is the other half. In Zoho Creator, an application is first built and tested in a protected space, and only then released to the "live" space where end users work. This separation prevents unfinished or buggy changes from disturbing live business data.

Environments in Zoho Creator

Zoho Creator supports a multi-environment model (availability depends on the subscription plan):

Environment	Purpose	Who uses it
Development	Build and modify forms, reports, pages, workflows, Deluge scripts	Developers
Stage	Testing / UAT with test data, close to production setup	Testers, business users
Production	Live application used for real operations	End users

Key ideas:

- Each environment has its own copy of the application and its own data.

- Application structure (forms, reports, pages, workflows, functions, schedules) is moved between environments. Records/data are generally not moved automatically.
- Changes in Production are not made directly; developers change Development, then promote.

Deployment Flow (Theory)

1. Development: build the application, unit test each form, workflow and script.

2. Deploy to Stage: package the current state of the application and push it to the Stage environment.

3. Testing / UAT: validate with sample data, check roles/permissions, integrations and reports.

4. Deploy to Production: after sign-off, promote the tested version to Production.

5. Post-deployment verification: confirm key flows work, connections are authorised, schedules run.

6. Maintenance: new fixes are made in Development and promoted again through the same pipeline.

Important Concepts

- Version / deployment history: each deployment is recorded so the team can see what was released and when.
- Pull changes: updates from a higher environment can be pulled back to keep environments aligned.
- Environment variables / connections: API keys, endpoints and OAuth connections often differ between Stage and Production and must be configured separately.
- Data migration: since data is not carried along with the structure, existing data is moved using Import (CSV/Excel), Export, or the Data APIs.
- Sharing and permissions: user roles and sharing settings should be reviewed after deployment because Production users differ from developers.
- Downtime and impact: structural changes (such as deleting a field) can affect existing records, so changes should be planned.

Pre-Deployment Checklist

- All forms, fields and lookups validated.
- Workflows and Deluge scripts tested with valid and invalid input.
- Reports and dashboards display expected data.
- Roles, profiles and permissions configured.
- Third-party connections (email, payment, APIs) re-authorised in the target environment.
- Backup/export of important data taken.
- Release notes prepared.

Best Practices

- Never edit Production structure directly.
- Use meaningful version notes for every deployment.
- Deploy in small, frequent releases rather than huge ones.
- Always test in Stage before Production.
- Keep a rollback plan (re-deploy last stable version / restore data backup).

Advantages

- Reduced risk to live data.
- Clear audit trail of changes.
- Better collaboration between developers, testers and business users.

Limitations

- Multi-environment features may require a higher plan.
- Data does not move with structure.
- Connections and configurations must be set again per environment.

Conclusion

Controlled deployment from Development through Stage to Production is a core part of the application lifecycle in Zoho Creator. It brings professional release management practices (testing, versioning, approval) to a low-code platform.